

THE GRANDPARENT AND THE SMARTPHONE

Show me. Don't take it.

A field-based look at the moment an older adult loses her footing on a smartphone, and what happens when the quickest help is to take the phone away.

RESEARCHER

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DATE

25 September 2026

LOCATION

Kumasi, Ghana

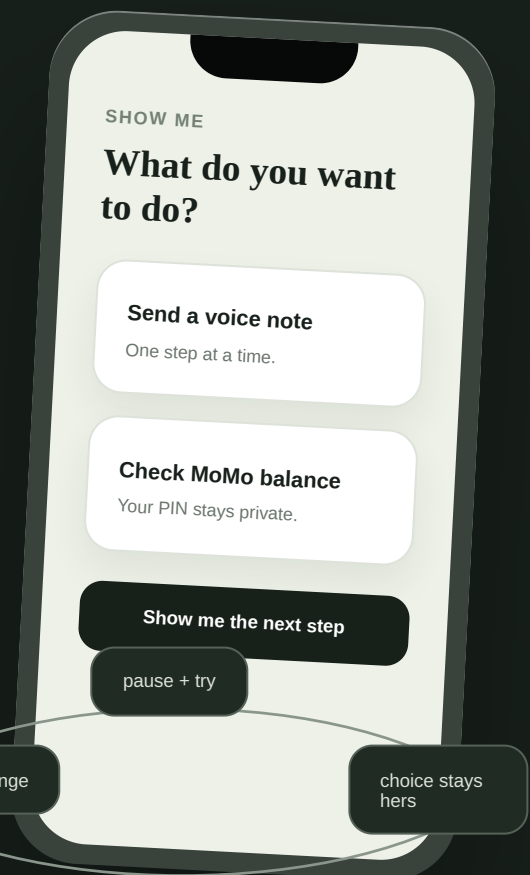
METHOD

Observation, interviews,
swap-seats

THE LOW POINT

A screen changes unexpectedly.
The phone moves from her hand
to someone else's.

unexpected change

choice stays
hers

What I actually saw

30 min

MAA EFUA SESSION

2 + 1

OLDER ADULTS + HELPER

1

SWAP-SEATS EXERCISE

Who I spent time with

PSEUDONYM	AGE	ROLE	CONTEXT
Maa Efua	70	Older adult edge case	Widow, retired seamstress, lives alone in a compound house in Asawase. JHS education. Reads Twi comfortably, not English. Weak eyesight. Entry-level Android, given by her daughter.
Papa Kojo	58	Older adult	Retired trader/driver in Ayigya. JHS plus some SHS. Reads simple English slowly. Avoids anything that looks technical.
Kwabena	19	Younger helper	Maa Efua's grandson and Papa Kojo's neighbour. The person who usually "fixes the phone" for both.

MAA EFUA / 30 MINUTE WHATSAPP VOICE NOTE

0:00-0:04

Fingerprint fails twice. Third attempt works.

0:04-0:09

She scrolls past WhatsApp twice. Kwabena taps it silently.

0:09-0:14

Finds Abena's chat correctly. Familiar path.

0:14-0:19 **LOW POINT**

Camera opens instead of microphone. She flinches and hands the phone over.

0:19-0:24

10 second pause. She backs out, finds the microphone, sends the note.

0:24-0:30

Kwabena takes the phone to check it. She gets it back on the home screen.

Observed

The key gap was not at the start of the task. She found the chat without help. The break happened when the screen did something she did not expect. When the helper waited, she recovered.

Papa Kojo's MoMo check took about 90 seconds without help. He read each option aloud before choosing.

Interpretation

The 10 second pause suggests that some dependency is reinforced by helpers moving too fast, not only by a lack of skill. The contrast between MoMo's sequential menu and WhatsApp's icons also suggests that visible, ordered steps feel safer to Papa Kojo.

The moments are small. The meaning is not.

QUOTE BANK

01

“Ei! Me de!”

Maa Efua • Observed. Camera opened instead of the microphone.

02

“Me nam so!”

Maa Efua • Observed. Right after she sent the voice note herself.

03

“Menhu no yiye. Biribiara sua sua.”

Maa Efua • Interview. Finding small icons.

05

“Me pa wo kyɛw, gyae, ma menyɛ bio.”

Maa Efua • Observed. Resisting the phone being taken.

06

“I don't read the English writing well, so I just press and see what happens.”

Maa Efua • Interview. Main workaround.

07

“Ɛyɛ den paa. I don't want to disturb the children every time, but I don't get option.”

Papa Kojo • Interview. Repeated dependence.

08

“Last week I checked my own balance for the first time in three months without calling anybody.”

Papa Kojo • Interview. Proud moment.

09

“The bank people changed the app and now everything is different. Nobody tell me.”

Papa Kojo • Interview. Sudden interface change.

10

“Auntie, no, no, let me do it, you go and sit.”

Kwabena • Observed. Taking the phone mid-task.

11

“Sometimes I just do it for them because explaining takes long and I have my own work too.”

Kwabena • Interview. Helper fatigue.

12

“If I show her once and she forgets, I get small vex, but I don't shout.”

Kwabena • Interview. Repeated teaching.

CONSENT + PRIVACY

Before each session I explained, in Twi and English, that there were no right or wrong answers, I would not touch or look at private messages, PINs, or balances, and the person could stop at any time.

“wo bɛ gyi me”

Maa Efua's first reaction before agreeing, “you will laugh at me.”

SWAP-SEATS

I set my own Android phone to French and tried to send a WhatsApp voice note and join a video call without changing it back.

I navigated by icon shape and position, not labels. I hesitated over closely placed icons. I relied on remembered position for the video call.

Try. Watch. Adjust. Back out if it is wrong.

That action and result loop became the basis for the artifact.

WHAT CHANGED IN MY UNDERSTANDING

I went in expecting an icon literacy problem. The observation pointed somewhere narrower. The difficult part was recovery.

A person, not a stereotype

SAYS

"Eɛɛ den paa."
 "Please just show me."
 "I did it myself!"
 "Everything is small small."

DOES

Taps the same icon several times when unsure. Hands the phone away quickly after an unexpected screen change. Quietly retries alone later.

THINKS

"If I press wrong, will I spoil it?" ?
 "Am I too old to learn this?" ?
 "I don't want to look foolish in front of the grandchildren." ?

FEELS

Embarrassed asking repeatedly. Anxious before an unfamiliar tap. Proud when something works without help. Quietly excluded when a helper finishes the task for her.

MA

Maa Adjoa
Boateng, 68

"When it works, I feel
like myself again."

LOCATION

A suburb of Kumasi, Ghana

BACKGROUND

Retired trader, JHS education, lives with extended family, speaks and reads Twi comfortably, reads little English.

PHONE

Entry-level Android smartphone, given to her by a younger relative.

GOAL

To send voice notes and check her own MoMo balance without waiting for a grandchild to be free.

FRUSTRATIONS

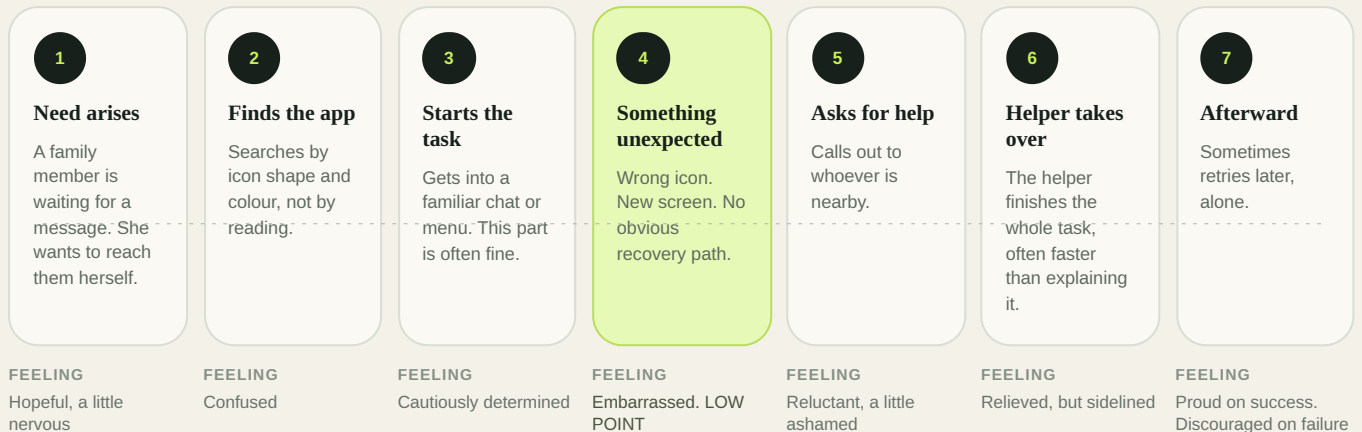
Small icons that look alike. English-only menus. Fear that pressing the wrong thing will "spoil" the phone. Helpers who finish tasks for her instead of with her. Layouts that change without warning.

"Me nam so!"

A moment of competence that happened only after the helper waited.

Evidence line: Composite of two older adults, aged 58 and 70, plus one younger helper aged 19. Observed and interviewed in Kumasi, Ghana, in September 2026.

Find the low point, then design from it



Why this low point holds: Maa Efua's camera and microphone mix-up happened at 0:14-0:19. My own swap-seats exercise produced the same kind of hesitation between closely placed icons. Both moments were about an unexpected change and the lack of an easy way back.

HOW MIGHT WE

Help older adults in Ghana recover on their own when a smartphone screen changes unexpectedly, so a small mistake does not have to end with someone else finishing the task for them?

Show Me, Don't Take It

People, channels, and the phone

The point is not one app. It is a recovery loop around the moments that cause the handover.

Phone shop attendant

Printed picture-card for the buyer's 3-4 priority tasks.

Peer buddy

Same-age teaching for one task at a time.

Older adult

Practices between sessions. Checks "what do I do from here?" without giving the phone away.

Family

Point, narrate, and record one short Twi voice guide per task.

Phone settings

Larger text and a simplified home screen, set once during setup.

community

minute "phone corner" on phones.

THE LOW POINT, STATED PLAINLY

Something unexpected happens. The fastest fix is to hand the phone over. That fixes the task, but it also removes the chance to recover.

HOW THE PIECES ANSWER IT

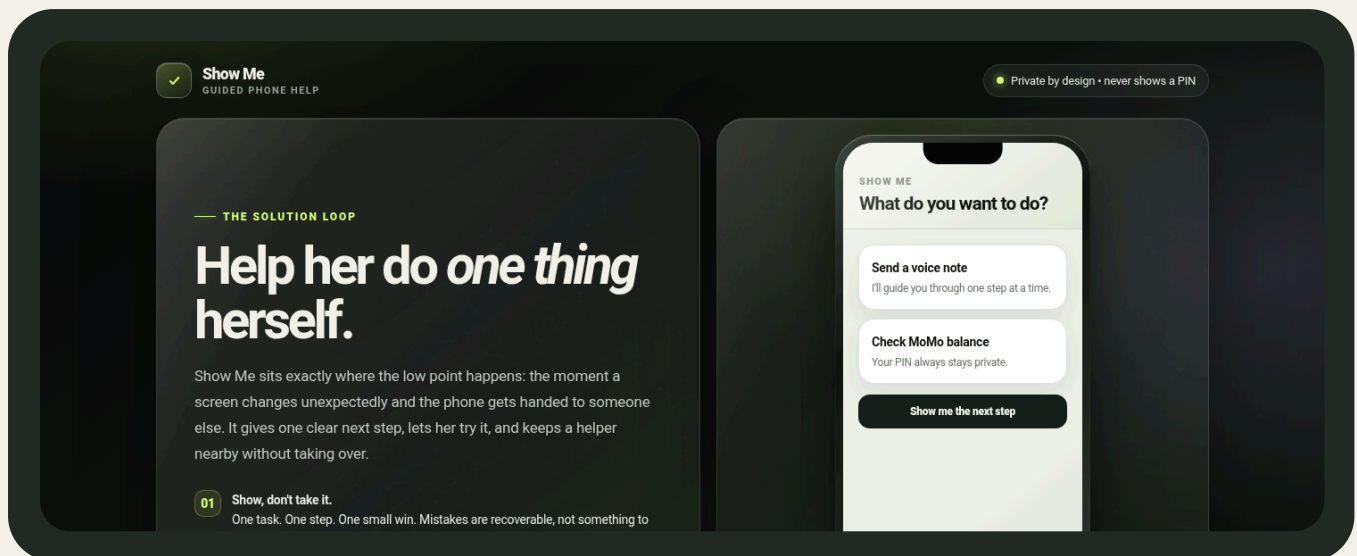
- 1 Show, don't grab.** Family members point or narrate instead of taking over immediately.
- 2 Leave a voice trail.** A short Twi guide can be replayed without asking someone again.
- 3 Give one visible cue.** Picture-cards reduce long text at the point of need.
- 4 Use peers too.** One same-age success can become a shared reference.

WHY THE ARTIFACT STARTS HERE

The website demo is the first touchpoint. It does not try to teach every phone feature. It gives one next action, a "Show me" cue, and a soft way to ask for help.

The private MoMo PIN step is intentionally stopped before the PIN. The system teaches where to tap. It does not ask for private information.

The thing she touches first



ARTIFACT

One task. One step. One small win.

The home screen offers four tasks from the field notes: Make a Call, Send Voice Note, Check MoMo Balance, and Join Video Call. The guide reveals one instruction at a time. "Show me" points to the next action. "I'm stuck" offers help without turning help into a failure.

01

Task-first

Start with the action, not a general menu.

02

One step

Only the next thing is asked for.

03

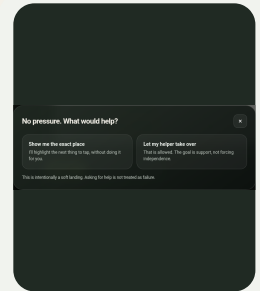
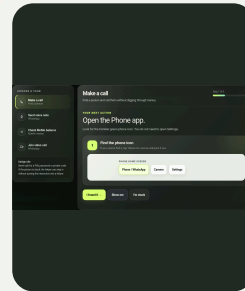
Visible result

Right and wrong taps have a clear, recoverable response.

04

Private step

MoMo stops before any PIN entry.



Check-back

Maa Efua: tapped "Send Voice Note," followed steps 1-2, then chose "Show me." "Ah, so it will show me small small before I try."

Papa Kojo: went straight to "Check MoMo Balance." "This one doesn't talk plenty. Good."

Sister Akosua: completed a video call, then missed the small Back button twice. "Eh, the back one is too small. I nearly pressed the wrong side of the screen."

One visible change

I widened the Back button's touch target and gave it a visible border. The change came from what a new tester actually did, at the same kind of recovery moment that shaped the original low point.

Artifact status: single self-contained HTML file. No external files, fonts, or network calls.

REFLECTION

Going in, I expected the low point to be "she doesn't understand icons," which would have pointed me toward more labels and text.

Watching the actual 30 minutes corrected that. Maa Efua understood the task fine and only lost her footing at the one moment a screen changed in a way she didn't expect. My own swap-seats attempt, in a language I don't read well, produced the same stumble at the same kind of moment.

I caught myself wanting to design an app that teaches her step by step. That assumed she needed a full course rather than a shorter safety net for the moments she already handles well.

The tension between what I expected, a learning problem, and what I actually saw, a recovery problem, shaped the final "Show me, don't take it" system.

WHAT I AM TAKING FROM THE SESSION

"Me nam so!"

The useful moment was not when someone fixed the phone quickly. It was the five seconds after the handover was delayed, when she found her way back and finished the task herself.

That is the moment the artifact is trying to protect.